

family life. That means your kids deserve a say in what the family does.

A retired friend from Southern California is the father of three boys, ages 14, 11, and 7. He assigns one weekend a month to each of them. He reserves that weekend for father and son to do anything the son wants to do. Anything? Dad is pretty flexible. In the past few years he and one or another of his boys have gone hang gliding, hired horses for a ride into the back country, flown to Las Vegas in a rented plane, gone to drag races, and torn up the San Bernardino Mountains with rented dirt bikes.

Other dads or moms, and sons or daughters, may have different ideas about how to spend their time. But retired parents can find out what their kids want to do and follow through. In most cases you'll find you have time for the kids and plenty of time for yourself as well.

Retired parents with kids travel less. Wanderlust is fine when it's just you and your spouse. But travel takes more out of kids than adults. Kids thrive on having a schedule, a certain amount of predictability in their lives. Travel exposes them to constant pressure to adapt. We saw in chapter 6 how hard we have to work to handle change. But because of their limited experience, children have to work even harder than adults do. It's cruel to disrupt their school, sleeping schedules, Girl Scout meetings, and Little League games just because you feel like sailing in the Caribbean.

Even so, your family can still travel. If the kids are in school you can travel for three months every summer and maybe a couple of weeks during Christmas vacation. And you can safely pull them out of school at other times if circumstances warrant.

Remember Nick and his family from chapter 7? Nick is a trader, one of those who seems never to work but always has enough money to get by. He and his French wife have a 16-year-old son and a 10-year-old daughter. A couple of years ago his son, then 14, seemed immature compared to the